MICHAEL (MIKE) GIBSON

Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of Maryland
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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Agricultural and Resource Economics — May 2027 (expected)
University of Maryland, College Park

Dissertation

Title: Harvesting the Toll: Rural Hospital Closures and the Health of American Farmers

Committee: Dr. Erich Battistin (Chair), Dr. Cory Smith, Dr. Louis Preonas

Abstract: This paper estimates how losing a local hospital affects access to care and health in rural America. Because a hospital serves patients well beyond its own county, I define treatment by health care market: every county in a Dartmouth Atlas hospital service area is treated when that market's hospital closes. Linking Sheps Center and Dartmouth Atlas closure records to mortality, provider, and economic data for 2001–2019, I estimate staggered and synthetic difference-in-differences models across 197 rural hospital closures. Closures increase the distance to the nearest hospital by about 3%, reduce primary care physicians per resident by 10%, and raise all-cause mortality by 1.3%, with effects concentrated among adults aged 55 and older.

M.S. in Agricultural and Resource Economics — May 2025
University of Maryland, College Park

M.S. in Economics — May 2018
Tufts University

B.A. in Economics, — May 2016
Wheaton College (Massachusetts)

RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics, Agricultural Economics, Applied Microeconomics

WORKING PAPERS

Manuscripts may be available at mtgibson.github.io; *selected paper abstracts are available at the end.*

1. **Gibson, M.** "Harvesting the Toll: Rural Hospital Closures and the Health of American Farmers"
2. **Gibson, M.** "Resource Booms or Curses: The impact of avocado export expansion on Michoacán"

WORKS IN PROGRESS

1. **Gibson, M.** "When Improving Agricultural Productivity Helps or Hurts: Sectoral Correlation and Growth Effects of Productivity Shocks"

TECHNICAL WRITING

1. **Gibson, M.** and A. Sautmann. "Introduction to randomized evaluations." J-PAL Research Resources (contributions from Laura Feeney and Claire Walsh)
2. **Gibson, M.** and A. Sautmann. "The elements of a randomized evaluation." J-PAL Research Resources (contributions from Laura Feeney and Claire Walsh)
3. **Gibson, M.** and W. Louw. "Survey programming." J-PAL Research Resources (contributions from Kathryn McDermott)
4. **Gibson, M.** "Data quality checks." J-PAL Research Resources (contributions from Ben Morse)
5. **Gibson, M.** "Implementation monitoring." J-PAL Research Resources (contributions from Arnesh Chowdhury, Maya Duru, Lipika Kapoor, Sarah Kopper, Wim Louw, Tithee Mukhopadhyay, and Clare Sachsse)
6. **Gibson, M.** and S. Kopper. "Resources for conducting remote surveys." J-PAL Research Resources (contributions from Marifatul Amalia, Saurabh Bhajibhakare, Putul Gupta, and Wim Louw)

INVITED TALKS

1. **Gibson, M.** "Resource Booms or Curses: The impact of avocado export expansion on Michoacán"

   Institute for Humane Studies (IHS) Winter Graduate Seminar 2024

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

1. **Gibson, M.** "Resource Booms or Curses: The impact of avocado export expansion on Michoacán"

   Western Economic Association International 99th Annual Conference, Seattle 2024

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Strategic Impact Evaluation Fund (SIEF) Fellow, World Bank

Dr. Alaka Holla & Dr. Anja Sautmann Jun. 2023 – present

Research Assistant, University of Maryland

Dr. Erik Lichtenberg & Dr. Lars Olson Dec. 2023 – Sep. 2024
Dr. Lori Lynch May 2022 – Jun. 2023

Masters Thesis, Tufts University

Dr. Melissa McInerney Sep. 2017 – May 2018
Contingency Plans: The Effects of Dependent Coverage Mandate on the Contingent Workforce Decisions of Young Adults

Research Assistant, Tufts University

Dr. Jenny Aker Sep. 2017 – May 2018
Harvesting the rain: The adoption of environmental technologies in the Sahel

EXTERNSHIP AND INTERNSHIP EXPERIENCES

Ignite@AG Externship, Analysis Group

Four-day externship at Analysis Group's Boston office Summer 2026

Completed a mock case on carriage fees between a TV producer and a network: estimated damages, built a but-for scenario, and presented the results

Shadowed an Associate on a telecommunications case, including how to value a firm's contribution to an industry standard, and joined case team meetings

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, University of Maryland, College Park

Undergraduate-level

AREC 241: Environment, Economics and Policy; Fall 2024
Dr. Lars Olson

AREC 280: Big Data and Climate Change; Fall 2023
Dr. Lars Olson

ECON/AREC 481: Environmental Economics; rating: **3.5/4** (N=7) Spring 2022
Dr. Roberton Williams, III

AREC 240: Introduction to Environmental Economics; rating: **3.4/4** (N=17) Spring 2022
Dr. Roberton Williams, III

AREC 365: World Hunger, Population, and Food; rating: **3.3/4** (N=3) Fall 2021
Dr. Ken Leonard

Head Teaching Assistant, Tufts University

Undergraduate-level

EC 05: Introduction to Economics Fall 2017, Spring 2018

Teaching Assistant, Tufts University

Undergraduate-level

EC 05: Introduction to Economics Fall 2016, Spring 2017

Undergraduate Teaching Assistant, Wheaton College (Massachusetts)

Macroeconomics I Spring 2015

AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Bessie H. DeVault Best Prospectus Award, University of Maryland, AREC 2025
Paper Accelerator Grant, ($5,000) Institute for Humane Studies 2023
Dean's Fellowship, University of Maryland 2021

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Reviewer, American Journal of Agricultural Economics 2025 – present
Graduate Representative for AREC, University of Maryland , College Park 2023, 2024
Graduate Student Government Member, University of Maryland, College Park 2023, 2024
Global Applications International Network Mentor 2021, 2022, 2024, 2025

LANGUAGE AND SKILLS

Language: English (native), Spanish (intermediate), French (beginner)
Software: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB, ArcGIS, LaTeX

SELECTED ABSTRACTS

1. **Gibson, M.** "Resource Booms or Curses: The impact of avocado export expansion on Michoacán"

   This paper documents the joint impacts of an export expansion and anti-drug trafficking policy on municipalities in avocado-producing states. I show theoretically that the policies could increase the profitability of avocado production in municipalities but expose them to cartel exploitation. Using a difference-in-difference approach, I show that after the policies are enacted, high-suitability municipalities expand avocado production yet experience only short-term income benefits. Consistent with the model, these municipalities are roughly 24% more likely to face cartel occupation after the policies are enacted. I rule out several alternative explanations and mechanisms for the lack of long-term benefits.

REFERENCES

Dr. Erich Battistin
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